Butterflies are Free

By Leonard Gershe

DON: *(Phone rings)* **(Pg 6-7)** *(Donny answers)* Hello, Mother . . . I'm fine, thank you. How are you? The apartment is great. I love it. Last night? I didn't do anything last night. I mean I didn't go out. I had some friends in – a little party . . . I don't know how many people were here. Do you have to have a number? Twelve and a half, how's that? When? No! We agreed to two months, didn't we? What? I can hardly hear you . . . What? We'll talk tomorrow. Goodbye.

INTRODUCTION

Young Don Baker, hero of his mother's children's book series, "Donny Dark" has been blind since birth. Don finally decides to take his own apartment in Manhattan and pursue his songwriting ambitions. But that's just when Mrs. Baker's controlling instincts go into overdrive. Butterflies are Free by Leonard Gershe

DON: *(To audience)* **(pg 10)** She didn't want me to leave home. She thinks I can't make it on my own. Finally, we agreed to letting me try it for two months. She's to keep away from me for two months. I've got a month to go . . . I always tell her I've had a party . . or went to one. She wouldn't understand why I'd rather be here alone than keeping her and the cook company. She'll hate this place. She'll walk in and the first thing she'll say is, "I could absolutely cry!" As far as my mother's concerned, I'm still eleven . . . going on ten. **(pg 14)** [Oh, yeah, and] I'm blind. I've always been blind. **(Pg 15)** Please don't feel sorry for me. The one thing that drives me up the wall is pity.

(Pg 24-25) You may have heard of [my mother]. She wrote a series of children's books. Guess what they were about? *(Beat)* A kid named little Donny Dark. It's true, I swear. I hate the name Donny. Donny is twelve years old and was born blind like me only it's no handicap to Little Donny Dark. He can drive cars and fly

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planes, 'cause, you see, his other faculties are so highly developed that he can hear a bank being robbed a mile away and he can smell the Communists cooking up a plot to overthrow the government. And at the end of every book, as he is being given a medal from the police or the C.I.A., he always says, "There are none so blind as those who will not see!" **(Pg 26)** I guess the books were sort of a projection of what my mother hoped I'd be – a sightless superman. **(Pg 38)** *(Don notices a change in the atmosphere, turns and says)* Mom . . . what are you doing here? We had an agreement.

MRS. BAKER: I was in the neighborhood. I bought you some shirts and I thought you'd have them sooner if I brought them myself.

DON: I don't need any shirts. You just brought them as an excuse to come down here.

MRS. BAKER: *(looking around the tiny apartment)* And this is what you left home for? It isn't Buckingham Palace, is it?

DON: **(Pg 41)** *(to audience)* I was so sure she'd walk in and say, "I could absolutely cry." She let me down.

MRS. BAKER: We'll there's only one thing to say. . . Perhaps it's a blessing that you can't see what you're living in.

DON: Right, Mom. I count that blessing every time I come in the door.

MRS. BAKER: Donny, can I be honest? . . . I am shocked and appalled. I could absolutely cry! *(Donny reacts with a "I won" gesture)* **(Pg 42)** I am not just talking about this rat hole, Donny, I am talking about you, too. You're so thin. You've lost weight.

DON: I haven't lost anything. I'm exactly the right weight for my height – and my age – eleven.

MRS. BAKER: *(Crossing to the refrigerator)* I'd like to see what you're eating. *(Opens the refrigerator and looks in)* There's nothing in here but lettuce . . . and an apple!

DON: **(Pg 45)** You're not supposed to be here for another month. Why did you have to come today, huh?

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MRS. BAKER: *(Steps toward Don)* Since when do you speak to me like this?

DON: Since when do you come sneaking into my room like this?

MRS. BAKER: I didn't come sneaking in. The door was unlocked.

DON: You could have knocked. I thought it was a raid.

MRS. BAKER: It should have been. **(Pg 46)** I thought my coming here would be a pleasant surprise for you. Had I known I'd be treated like . . .

DON: *(Don cuts her off)* You'd've come anyway.

MRS. BAKER: And I'm glad I did. My worst fears have been realized. Did you have to choose such a sordid neighborhood?

DON: Thank heaven! ***My*** worst fear was that ***your*** worst fears wouldn't be realized. Can you imagine if you came here and liked it? We'd have nothing to talk about.

MRS. BAKER: **(Pg 47)** You don't know what you're talking about. You've never been exposed to life.

DON: Whose fault is that? Whose fault is it I didn't go to school with other kids?! *(to audience)* **(Pg 15)** I was six years old before I found out everyone else wasn't blind. . . **(Pg 48)** *(back to Mom)* There are schools for blind children.

MRS. BAKER: We could afford to have you taught at home. I thought that was better than sending you off with a bunch of blind children like . . a leper.

DON: Is that how you see me – like a leper? Come on, Mom, deep, deep down haven't you always been just a little ashamed of producing a blind child? *(beat)*

MRS. BAKER: *(avoids the question – she turns to Don enthusiastically)* Donny, I have a wonderful idea! You come home with me. *(Don shakes his head)* **(Pg 49)** If you insist on staying here, I will not support you. I'm serious, Donny! What are you going to do for money?

DON: I can always walk along the street with a tin cup . . . Don't worry, Mom. *(beat)* [Fine] I'm going to sing and play the guitar. I'm pretty good. You've said so yourself.

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MRS. BAKER: I didn't know you were planning to make a career of it. May I ask how you arrived at this brilliant decision?

DON: My dear mother – by the process of elimination. I made a list of all the things I couldn't do . . . like commercial pilot. **(Pg 50)** Photographer? A definite out – along with ball player and cab driver. I half considered becoming an eye doctor, but that would just be a case of the blind leading the blind. That was a joke, Mom. *(Mrs. Baker finds Don's suitcase and starts packing his clothes)* What are you doing?

MRS. BAKER: What I should have done long ago. I'm taking you home. You cannot stay here alone!

DON: **(Pg 51)** Mom, please stop worrying about me. *(Don takes the suitcase away from his mother, who relinquishes it with resignation)* I'm going to be all right. If the music doesn't work out, I can always study law or technology. There are lots of things blind people can do now . . . **(Pg 50)** [and] I have friends. I'm not alone.

MRS. BAKER: Oh, don't think you've fooled me with all your parties. There are no parties! You have no friends, Donny!

DON: **(Pg 62)** Don! . . . Donald! You can call me Sebastian or Irving. I don't care. Anything but Donny! **(Pg 61)** It reminds me of Little Donny Dark.

MRS. BAKER: **(Pg 70)** Do you remember the first Donny Dark story? You were five years old. We were spending the summer on [the] lake. It was the first time you'd been in any water deeper than a bathtub. You were terrified. They could hear you screaming all over New Hampshire. Dad brought you in and I told you a story about a little blind boy who could swim the seven seas and could talk to the dolphins.

DON: *(remembering, bitterly)* Yeah . . . and the dolphins told him about enemy submarines on their way to destroy the United States Navy and Donny Dark swam home in time to save them. What a lot of crap.

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MRS. BAKER: The next day you learned to swim! **(Pg 71)** I didn't write those stories hoping for a Pulitzer prize. I wrote them because I found a way to help you. Whenever you felt discouraged or defeated, I told you a Donny Dark story . . . and you tried a little harder and you did a little better. *(beat - considering)* You're not the boy who left home a month ago. I came down here today hoping you were. It's hard to adjust to not being needed anymore. But I can do it . . . you get on with your own life. I love you, Don. *(Mrs. Baker leaves)*

DON: *(picks up his guitar and plays/sings)* * I knew the day you met me, I could love you if you let me, though you touched my check and said, How easy you'd forget me . . . You said . . . *(he now has the words)* **(Pg 20)** Butterflies are free and so are we . . . *(to audience)* [You like it?] I wrote it . . . I've been working on it, but I could never get those last lines right. *(sings again)* Butterflies are free and so are we . .

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Leonard Gershe
ISBN: 978-0573606441
Publisher: Samuel French, Inc
Date (Month/Year): November 2010

AWARD HISTORY

2007 National Qualifier

Song can be found at https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nTylTLB-VNI

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